

new working environment. For instance, at the start of the pandemic, Google recognised that its managers were key to managing the transition their teams were going through. So, it invested in providing managers with the resources they needed to lead their teams in this ambiguous environment. Google had managers virtually learning from each other, learning in the moment through short videos that provided advice, or through a panel of managers who addressed the most frequently asked questions pertaining to managing remote teams and supporting well-being. It also encourages its leaders to keep learning, and its education reimbursement programme offers eligible Googlers in India from all levels \$4,000 annually to participate in personal or business-critical courses to directly improve a skill outside of what's offered at Google.

For women, it has specific programmes. "We want to do our part to not only offer attractive jobs for women to join tech but also enable more women to develop skills that are vital in the modern digital world," says Tampling. One such initiative is DigiPivot—in association with Avatar and the Centre for Executive Education at the Indian School of Business—that trains women in digital marketing to open up more opportunities for them to pivot into the tech sector or gain new skills as they widen their skill sets. In addition, Google Career Certificates, launched last year, bridges the digital skills gap between job seekers and employers. Google has recently strengthened the programme in India with 100,000 scholarships and a cohort of companies that will recognise these for their resource requirements.

"Whether it's here in India where we have a vibrant community of Googlers or across the globe, we wanted to ensure we were finding relevant ways to keep our learning culture alive by constantly asking ourselves, 'how can we enhance the existing programmes we have?'; 'how can we support our employees further?' and 'what are we missing?'" And it wasn't just for the current workforce but Nooglers (new employees) too. Google redesigned its on-boarding programme in six months, and has partnered with more than 30 teams to brainstorm what Nooglers need to be successful.

Google is also sensitive towards its employees as they shifted aspects of their personal and professional lives from short-term survival mode to longer-term adaptive recovery with new routines. While the company believes in the value of coming together in the office in person, it also believes that Googlers should have the flexibility to work. While employees continue to work from home, Google acknowledges that everyone's experience is different. And hence, it is offering flexible working arrangements among the many options provided.



Key HR initiatives

- Used multiple data sources to get the whole picture about how Googlers felt
- Introduced up to 14 weeks of paid leave to be used according to employees' personal caregiving needs
- Rolled out global day-offs so that employees could take a break and recharge themselves
- Education reimbursement of \$4,000 annually for personal or business-critical courses; DigiPivot programme for women
- Flexible work arrangements—three days in office, two days wherever they work best; four weeks of work a year from a remote location

Back in May 2021, Google had announced its future workplace as a hybrid environment where Googlers will spend approximately three days in the office and two days wherever they work best. And for flexible work arrangements, employees have the opportunity to temporarily work from a location other than their main office for up to four weeks per year.

"We know that in terms of where technology is today, nothing replaces the power of human interaction and the chemistry people have when they come together. And this is why we're investing so much in our tools and spaces—to ensure a truly connected and equitable experience for all of our employees," says Tampling. **BT**

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